

Startup Marketing Checklist

A practical checklist for getting the marketing fundamentals in place before you spend heavily or try to scale.

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Marketing gets a lot easier when you stop trying to do everything at once. Start with the basics: know who you want to reach, make the offer clear, give people a sensible way to take the next step, and decide how you will tell whether any of it is working.

This checklist is built for a new or early-stage business. It is not a mandate to be on every platform or spend a certain amount of money. Use it to make the important decisions visible, then work down the list in the order that makes sense for the business.

A useful reminder: activity is not the same thing as traction. A full content calendar can coexist with weak demand. A small amount of traffic can be valuable when it comes from the right people and leads to real conversations, bookings, purchases, or trials.

1. Start with the offer

Before you worry about channels, make sure you can explain what you are asking people to buy.

- ☐ Write the problem the business solves in plain language.
- ☐ Define the primary offer and exactly what the customer receives.
- ☐ State who the offer is for and who it is not designed for.
- ☐ List the strongest alternatives, including doing nothing or doing the work internally.
- ☐ Write the main reason someone might choose your offer over those alternatives.
- ☐ Identify the proof you can show today: examples, demonstrations, results, expertise, credentials, partnerships, or customer evidence.
- ☐ Review public claims for accuracy. Advertising claims should be truthful, not misleading, and supported by a reasonable basis.

2. Know the first customer

Your first useful audience is usually narrower than “anyone who needs this.”

- ☐ Describe the customer by situation, problem, buying trigger, and need - not demographics alone.
- ☐ Write down what causes the customer to start looking for a solution.
- ☐ List the questions they ask before spending money.
- ☐ List objections that can stop the purchase and the evidence that answers them.
- ☐ Capture the words customers actually use to describe the problem and desired outcome.
- ☐ Separate people who could benefit from the offer from people who are likely to buy now.

3. Get the message straight

You should be able to carry the same basic message from your website to a sales call without changing what the business is promising.

- ☐ Write a one-sentence value proposition.
- ☐ Choose 2-4 message themes you will repeat consistently.
- ☐ Make the primary benefit easier to find than the company history.
- ☐ Remove internal jargon that a new customer would not understand.
- ☐ Check that your visual identity supports the position you are claiming.
- ☐ Decide what you will not claim until you have evidence to support it.

4. Make the website ready to acquire customers

The website does not need to be enormous. It needs to make the next step obvious.

- ☐ The homepage makes clear what you do, who it is for, and what to do next.
- ☐ Core offers have enough information for a visitor to evaluate them.
- ☐ Calls to action match the visitor stage: learn, compare, contact, book, buy, request a quote, or start a trial.
- ☐ Forms work on mobile and ask only for information you need.
- ☐ Important pages have useful titles, headings, links, and indexable content.
- ☐ The site loads reliably and does not create avoidable friction on mobile.
- ☐ A real conversion path exists from first visit to lead or sale.

5. Measure before you scale

You do not need a complicated dashboard. You do need to know what happened after someone arrived.

- ☐ Define the business outcomes that matter most right now.
- ☐ Measure meaningful actions such as qualified form submissions, bookings, purchases, calls, or trial starts.
- ☐ Separate traffic metrics from business outcomes.
- ☐ Use consistent campaign naming so sources can be compared.
- ☐ Document how a marketing lead becomes a sales opportunity or customer.
- ☐ Decide what evidence would make you increase, change, or stop a channel.
- ☐ Test the tracking yourself before launching paid campaigns.

6. Choose channels based on customer behavior

The right channel is the place where your customer is actually reachable, not necessarily the platform everyone is talking about.

- ☐ List where the customer already searches, compares, asks for recommendations, or spends attention.
- ☐ Choose only the first few channels you can maintain well.
- ☐ For search, make sure important pages are discoverable and follow Google Search Essentials.
- ☐ For paid ads, define the audience, offer, landing page, conversion action, budget, and stop conditions before launch.
- ☐ For referral or partner marketing, define the referral trigger and make the handoff easy.
- ☐ For social media, decide whether the channel is serving discovery, education, proof, community, or direct response.
- ☐ Do not add another channel simply because the current one is not working; first identify what is actually failing.

7. Build a useful content engine

Good startup content usually comes from the questions your sales conversations keep surfacing.

- ☐ Create a list of the questions prospects ask repeatedly.
- ☐ Turn those questions into useful pages, FAQs, emails, demos, videos, or social posts.
- ☐ Create proof content from real work instead of generic promotional statements.
- ☐ Give each piece of content a job: explain, compare, demonstrate, reassure, or move the reader forward.
- ☐ Update strong content before creating more of the same.
- ☐ Remove or correct content that is outdated, misleading, or too thin to be useful.

8. Prepare the customer handoff

Getting the lead is only part of acquisition. Someone has to know what happens next.

- ☐ Decide who owns new leads.
- ☐ Set an expected response time.
- ☐ Write the first follow-up message or call outline.
- ☐ Create a simple qualification process.
- ☐ Define what happens to leads that are not ready to buy.
- ☐ Track source and outcome so marketing can learn from actual customer quality.
- ☐ Make sure the sales or fulfillment experience matches the promise made in marketing.

9. Set a responsible budget

A startup budget should buy learning as well as reach.

- ☐ Know the maximum amount you can afford to test without putting core operations at risk.
- ☐ Set a test budget before choosing the campaign.
- ☐ Estimate the value of a new customer and the maximum acquisition cost the business can support.
- ☐ Separate media spend from creative, software, agency, and labor costs.
- ☐ Define a review date before the campaign starts.
- ☐ Do not keep spending just because money has already been spent.

10. Run experiments, not guesses

The goal of the first campaigns is to learn what deserves more attention.

- ☐ Write the hypothesis before changing the campaign.
- ☐ Change one meaningful variable at a time when practical.
- ☐ Choose a primary metric before looking at the result.
- ☐ Record the date, audience, offer, creative, landing page, and result.
- ☐ Look at lead quality, not only clicks or traffic.
- ☐ Keep a short experiment log so decisions are based on evidence rather than memory.
- ☐ Scale only after the underlying process is working consistently enough to support more volume.

At the end of the first 30-90 days: you should know more about your customer, your offer, and the channels that can reach them than you knew on day one. That learning is the real foundation for growth.

What is ready, and what is not?

Use this page as a working review rather than a grade. A “No” is useful when it tells you exactly what needs attention next.

Area	Status	What needs attention?
Offer	☐ Ready ☐ Not yet	
Customer definition	☐ Ready ☐ Not yet	
Positioning / message	☐ Ready ☐ Not yet	
Website / conversion path	☐ Ready ☐ Not yet	
Measurement	☐ Ready ☐ Not yet	
Acquisition channels	☐ Ready ☐ Not yet	
Content / proof	☐ Ready ☐ Not yet	
Lead follow-up	☐ Ready ☐ Not yet	
Budget / stop conditions	☐ Ready ☐ Not yet	
Experiment plan	☐ Ready ☐ Not yet	

Sources

Google Analytics guidance supports measuring lead form views, submissions, and meaningful business actions rather than relying only on traffic. Google Search Essentials provides baseline guidance for pages intended to appear in Google Search. FTC guidance establishes that advertising claims should be truthful, not deceptive or unfair, and supported by evidence.

Google Analytics: <https://support.google.com/analytics/answer/12941105>

Google Analytics key events: <https://support.google.com/analytics/answer/12946393>

Google Search Essentials: <https://developers.google.com/search/docs/essentials>

FTC Advertising FAQ: <https://www.ftc.gov/business-guidance/resources/advertising-faqs-guide-small-business>